Foreign Influence by Authoritarian Governments: Introducing New Data and Evidence

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Policymakers are increasingly concerned about the revival of superpower conflict. Increased competition among great powers has been especially evident in the exercise of foreign influence, where Russia and China have increased their efforts to influence less powerful nations. To date, the absence of quantitative data has limited systematic investigation of this resurgence of authoritarian influence activity. We introduce a new, country-month dataset tracking reports of influence by Russia and China in 66 aid-receiving low- and middle-income countries from 2012 through August 2025. We construct the data by applying large language models (LLMs) to an original corpus of more than 120 million news articles sourced from high-quality, domestic news sources and use it to describe trends in influence activity over time and across countries. Finally, as a test case, use the data to examine Russian influence activity in the months before the invasion of Ukraine. We document a dramatic, previously undetected, pre-invasion surge in diplomacy and hard power reporting across many countries. In doing so, we show that this data is useful for both theory testing and foreign policy decision-making.

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Introduction

The last 15 years have seen Russia and China become both more autocratic and more assertive in their foreign policies (Diamond 2020). Both have increased efforts to influence less powerful nations and secure strategic partnerships. Scholars and policymakers have voiced growing concerns about a resurgence of authoritarian influence, driving high-level foreign policy decisions and major investments by Western governments in strengthening ties with strategically important countries.

These developments are unfolding amid broader concerns about a "new Cold War" between Western democracies and the "new axis" coalition (Sanger 2024; The White House 2017; Evans and Stark 2019). Despite the importance of these issues, a lack of systematic quantitative data has limited rigorous investigation. Assembling such data is difficult: influencing and target countries rarely publish administrative records of influence activity, and less dramatic influence activities rarely receive international media attention. This creates a measurement gap in the contexts that matter most.

In this paper, we introduce the *Resurgent Authoritarian Influence (RAI)* dataset. *RAI* tracks monthly reporting across 21 influence categories in 66 aid-receiving low- and middle-income countries from 2012 through August 2025. We focus on aid-receiving countries because these are settings where influence efforts are often prominent. To build the data, we apply a fine-tuned transformer-based language model to a corpus of more than 120 million news articles published by over 350 high-quality media outlets, most of them domestic, in 40 languages. The result is a high-frequency measure of *reported* influence activity by tool and country. *RAI* is a media-based measure of reporting intensity, not a record of unique events, but validation shows that it strongly correlates with real Russian and Chinese foreign activities.

We proceed in four parts. First, we briefly review extant work on Russian and Chinese foreign influence and outline the strengths and limitations of existing data on the topic. Second, we introduce *RAI* and its underlying *High-Quality Media from Aid Receiving Countries (HQMARC)* corpus, document our pipeline, and report on several validation exercises. Third, we describe how Russia and China vary their influence tools across space and time. Fourth, we provide a use case that examines Russian influence activity in the months before the invasion of Ukraine. Using change-point analysis, AI-assisted qualitative case studies, and regression we document a substantial, previously undetected, pre-invasion surge in diplomacy and hard power reporting across many countries. We also demonstrate that pre-invasion surges in Russian activity were concentrated in the countries and influence tools that are consistent with extant arguments in international relations theory.

In doing so, we show that *RAI* is a valuable resource for researchers and policymakers alike. For researchers, our data provides a complement to existing data on Chinese financial and diplomatic activities (Goodman et al. 2024; Custer et al. 2021), enables description of how shifts in influence strategies unfold over months and countries, and allows tests of how influence tools substitute for or complement one another across major geopolitical shocks. For policymakers, it provides a transparent, updateable gauge of how influence is reported in target-countries and provides hard data to inform policy responses to the foreign influence of Russia and China. Throughout, we emphasize that *RAI* measures *reporting* on influence activity—not verified actions—and is best interpreted as a high-frequency, multidimensional indicator of RAI salience.

Russian and Chinese Foreign Influence

Over the past 20 years, Russia and China have increasingly asserted themselves on the global stage, challenging the liberal international order and and seeking to reshape global dynamics in their favor. (Sanger 2024; Fukuyama 2015). Russia's invasions of Georgia and Ukraine and its annexation of Crimea signal a willingness to redraw borders by force. China has pursued assertive policies in the South China Sea and used the Belt and Road Initiative to extend economic and political influence across Asia, Africa, and Europe. Both have sought to undermine Western influence through cyber operations, strategic alliances, and information campaigns.

Influence strategies are inherently multi-dimensional. States deploy coercive tools (e.g., military assistance, sanctions) or non-coercive tools (e.g., public diplomacy, cultural engagement), targeting elites or publics depending on objectives and constraints. Changes in influence behavior thus manifest not only in *how active* states are, but *which tools* they emphasize and *where*. A central goal of *RAI* is to make those shifts empirically visible.

This framework yields testable expectations. If tools are complements, coordinated increases should appear across diplomacy, economic, and security categories during periods of strategic pressure. If tools are substitutes, we should observe tradeoffs between coercive and non-coercive instruments. Reporting on Russia's footprint in Africa—where security assistance, political engagement, and information operations often blend together—illustrates why a multi-dimensional measurement approach is necessary (Ferragamo 2023; Gain 2023; Hairsine 2023; Reuters 2024).

Concerns with RAI have driven major policy responses. For instance, in 2019, USAID launched the *Countering Malign Kremlin Influence Development Framework* and the *Countering Chinese Influence Fund* (USAID 2022). That same year, the Export-Import Bank of the U.S. announced the China and Transformational Export Program (CTEP) to help U.S. exporters facing competition from China. And in 2022, the U.S. responded to a Chinese-Solomon Islands security agreement by reopening its embassy and inviting Pacific leaders to Washington (Zongyuan 2022). Similarly, the EU launched its €300 billion Global Gateway infrastructure scheme as a rival to China's BRI.

Despite this policy attention, quantitative data on authoritarian influence remains sparse. The most comprehensive existing data comes from AidData, which covers China's foreign aid and state financing to low- and middle-income countries from 2000–2017 and annual diplomatic events in some Asian countries (Goodman et al. 2024; Custer et al. 2021). This work has yielded valuable findings: Chinese aid and investment reduce conflict (Gehring, Kaplan, and Wong 2019; Strange et al. 2017), increase economic growth (Dreher et al. 2021; Knutsen and Kotsadam 2020) and repression (Gehring, Kaplan, and Wong 2019; Kishi and Raleigh 2017), decrease membership in trade unions (Isaksson and Kotsadam 2018) and citizen support for democracy (Gehring, Kaplan, and Wong 2019), and increase public support for China (Dreher, Lang, and Reinsberg 2024).[1] But AidData covers only Chinese influence, is updated sporadically, and focuses on a limited range of tools. Research has consequently been confined largely to economic influence, leaving diplomacy, hard power, soft power, and domestic interference comparatively understudied (Nye 2023; Kurlantzick 2007; Kinne 2018).

RAI addresses these gaps. It covers both Russia and China and spans 21 influence activities. Our approach provides unique, high-frequency data on how Russia and China have wielded their economic and hard power (military capacity, security agreements, and defense cooperation) to influence both regional and the international economic order (Goldstein 2020; Maier 1977) and pursued overlapping

[1]This last finding does not hold for respondents closest to the aid projects [@blair2022foreign].

economic and military cooperation with less powerful nations (Gowa and Mansfield 1993). Likewise, we provide systematic data on the use of soft and diplomatic power (Nye 2023; Kurlantzick 2007), i.e., non-coercive efforts to shape foreign preferences through public diplomacy, cultural engagement, and information campaigns. Russia and China deploy these tools by establishing cultural centers (Russian Embassy Cambodia 2021) and launching media campaigns (Cook 2021). Russia and China also promote their interests using diplomatic maneuvers, including formal statements, official visits, and participation in diplomatic mediation (Legarda 2018; Zuvela and Vasovic 2019). Data tracking the timing and location of soft power and diplomatic engagement can produce new insights into how and when non-coercive strategies influence target-country politics, and whether these tools are used as substitutes or complements to coercive forms of influence (Ku and Mitzen 2022; Putnam 1988; Allan, Vucetic, and Hopf 2018).

We also provide data on domestic interference efforts to create pressure on-or provide assistance to-target governments (Lim and Mukherjee 2019). For Russia and China, this has included everything from surveillance and cyber-attacks (Holland and Chiacu 2021) to collecting intelligence on the political opposition,(BBC News 2019b) engaging in cyber attacks against independent news sources,(Balkan Insight 2020) and transferring surveillance technology (Kafeero 2020). Finally, we provide data on the extent to which efforts to exert influence have unintended consequences. For example, Chinese influence has been linked to increased corruption (Brazys, Elkink, and Kelly 2017; Isaksson and Kotsadam 2018) and the spread of Chinese organized crime (U.S. Department of Justice 2003).Consistent with those findings, perceptions of Russian and Chinese influence have caused anti-incumbent mobilization in many countries (BBC News 2019a; Jalloh and Wan 2019). Data on these adverse types of influence allow research into the ability of Russia and China to effectively manage their influence operations.

Below we describe the RAI dataset. By tracking a broad set of tools at high frequency, the data enables new work on when and how states seek cooperation or control (Kinne 2013; Lake 1996), how influence tools substitute for or complement one another (Ku and Mitzen 2022; Putnam 1988), and how influence strategies respond to short-term geopolitical dynamics rather than only to long-run structural forces.

The Resurgent Authoritarian Influence Dataset

RAI tracks *reporting* on 21 influence categories associated with Russian and Chinese foreign influence. Each category captures reporting on actions by a government or state-linked actor intended to shape another country's domestic or foreign policy. We developed the categories by reviewing prior research and consulting with civil-society and policy partners. We group the 21 categories into six broader themes and construct theme indices by summing category-level reporting intensities. Table 1 lists the themes, definitions, and categories.[2]

Measurement and interpretation. The classifier assigns category labels to article text, which we aggregate into monthly reporting indices. Primary analyses focus on six thematic indices, which are more stable than fine-grained categories. We report classifier performance and training details in the Supplementary Materials. *RAI* measures *reported* influence activity, not verified actions; covert behaviors such as intelligence and cyber operations are likely underreported and should be treated as lower bounds. We mitigate editorial bias by normalizing by total article volume, presenting both absolute levels and relative shares, and grounding analysis in within-country changes over time.

[2]See Supplementary Materials *Category Definitions* for category-level definitions.

Table 1: RAI Categories Grouped by Theme

Theme	Definition	Categories
Soft Power	Non-coercive efforts to shape attitudes or preferences among publics and elites through information or cultural engagement.	Media Campaign/Intervention Social/Academic/Cultural Activity
Hard Power	Military or security cooperation and activity that strengthens coercive capacity or military ties.	Arms Transfer/Security Aid/Assistance Joint Security Force Exercise Security Engagement Military Activity
Economic Power	Use of aid, investment, technology transfer, or trade measures to shape economic ties or incentives.	Foreign Aid/Assistance Foreign Investment Technology Transfer/Investment Trade Agreement/Exchange Trade/Financial Sanction
Diplomacy	Actions that expand, reduce, or signal official diplomatic relations, statements, meetings, mediation, or punitive diplomatic actions.	Diplomatic Mediation Diplomatic Ties Diplomatic Action Diplomatic Statement Diplomatic Meeting
Domestic Interference	Non-military interference targeting domestic politics or information systems, including espionage, cyber operations, or policy manipulation.	Intelligence/Counterintelligence Political Process/Policy Intervention Cyber Attack
Backlash	Unintended or illicit consequences associated with influence attempts.	Bribery/Economic Corruption Transnational Organized Crime

The dataset covers 66 aid-receiving countries from 2012 through August 2025—a deliberate scope condition that enables consistent, high-frequency measurement where domestic coverage is richest, but does not capture influence efforts in advanced democracies.

To collect reporting on RAI, we built the *HQMARC* corpus, covering 66 countries from 2012 through August 2025. *HQMARC* includes more than 120 million articles from 16 international outlets, 12 regional outlets, and 326 domestic newspapers. Domestic sources account for 95% of articles, with a median of 5 domestic sources per country (see Supplementary Materials *Distribution of Domestic Sources*). This extensive domestic coverage is key because large international outlets barely cover many countries and only the most egregious influence efforts when they do.

We identify domestic sources using university library guides, Reporters Sans Frontieres profiles, and partner recommendations. We include both independent and state-affiliated sources, aiming for at least 50% independent coverage per country; where this is not achievable, we apply weighting to reduce the influence of heavily state-aligned ecosystems (see Supplementary Materials *Source Weighting*).

Rather than using generic crawlers or pre-canned scraping tools, we build custom scrapers and parsers to capture each outlet's complete publication history. This approach yields higher coverage and stability than large aggregators such as GDELT, Common Crawl, or the Internet Archive. *HQMARC's* human-supervised scraping produces a corpus with a more stable, well-understood composition than widely used alternatives (Adiguzel et al. 2024).[3] We overwhelmingly rely on open-access content.

To accommodate a large volume of articles in diverse languages, we translate articles into English and then extract locations and influence categories from the translated text. Given the well-documented biases in English-language news sources (Baum and Zhukov 2015) even on relatively uncontroversial topics like natural disasters (Brimicombe 2022), we include non-English newspapers in our corpus.[4] See Supplementary Materials *Languages in HQMARC* for a list of languages by country.

To classify influence categories, we fine-tuned a ModernBERT-large classifier on 10,329 labeled articles (22 classes including `-999` for articles that do not clearly fit any category). We evaluate with 5-fold cross-validation and a held-out test set (n = 1,550). Cross-validation accuracy averages 0.926 with macro F1 of 0.885; held-out test accuracy is 0.923 with macro F1 of 0.883. Performance is strongest for high-signal categories (e.g., cyber attack, joint military exercise) and lower for linguistically diffuse categories such as diplomatic statements. For this reason, our analysis below emphasizes theme-level indices; category-level patterns are reported in the Supplementary Materials.

To identify foreign influence reporting involving Russia or China, we built a keyword library to detect mentions of Russian and Chinese agencies, companies, or officials. See Supplementary Material *Using Keywords to Detect Influence* for the keyword list, development process, and validation tests. To ensure that reporting is assigned to the correct target country, we geoparse the first 600 characters

[3]Depending on website architecture, we obtain news articles by scraping sitemaps, newspaper archives, or by simulating infinite scrolling using Selenium. We de-duplicate articles based on URL and title similarity. We update these scrapers on a quarterly basis to maintain accuracy and comprehensiveness.

[4]We use neural machine translations (NMT) through Hugging Face or OpenNMT to translate into English. We test the efficacy of all translation models by extracting sample text and running the text through all available translation models on the Hugging Face open database. We then assess whether the translations are sufficient to identify the main influence category being reported on. If they are not, we compare the performances with those of our other APIs and choose the one that yields the optimal sentence-to-sentence translations with sufficient human readability.

of text and identify all locations mentioned. If no country is found, we assign the article to the country in which the publishing outlet is based.[5]

We aggregate these data to the country-month level, normalizing the count of articles reporting on each influence category by the total number of articles published in that country-month. Because only a small portion of news coverage focuses on foreign influence, we report *RAI* activity as articles per 10,000 published in each country-month. The resulting measures are *shares of reporting*, not verified counts of discrete actions or incidents, and they capture how frequently each influence category is reported relative to overall news volume. We construct theme indices by summing category-specific reporting intensities within each theme (Table 1), and we also construct a total index that sums across all categories for Russia, China, and both influencing countries combined. Finally, we supplement those measures with an indicator variable identifying months when major RAI "surges" occurred. To do so, we developed an ensemble algorithm to detect large increases in the share of reporting dedicated to event categories. We refer to these increases as *surges*. Full details on model design, parameter tuning, and validation are provided in Supplemental Material.

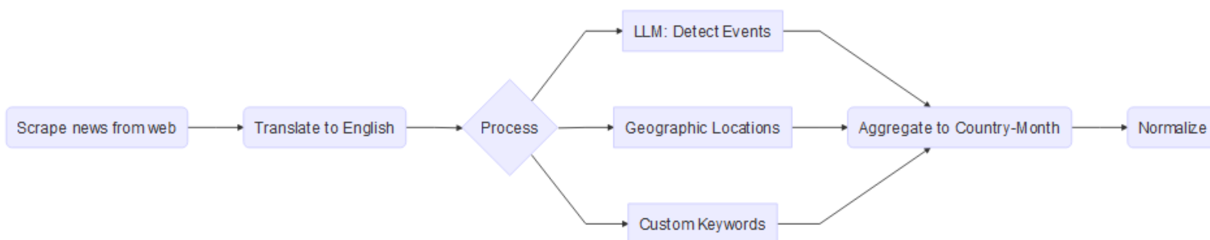

Figure 1: RAI data production pipeline.

The supplementary pipeline schematic provides a graphic representation of the *RAI* data production pipeline. We update each country about every 90 days. Quality assurance measures are in place at multiple steps in this process. Before processing, we check every source to ensure that the volume of articles and their distribution across days conform to past updates. After processing, we calculate correlations between old and new data and check a standard set of comparison visualizations.

Above we report that out-of-sample model accuracy is 0.923 at the level of individual articles. To further validate the RAI data we conduct two exercises. First, we audit significant change-point months when well-documented episodes (e.g., coups, diplomatic recognition switches) should be reflected in increases in RAI activity. Second, we audit 86 randomly selected RAI surges encompassing 872 individual articles to assess whether they accurately reflect real-world events.[6]

Turning to our first exercise, an abundance of high-profile cases illustrate major influence operations by both countries. For Russia, perhaps the most dramatic example has been the country's recent

[5]For international and regional outlets, articles are only assigned to a country if they explicitly mention a location within that country. We use the CLIFF-CLAVIN geoparser with the GeoNames ontological gazetteer. GeoNames is one of the most comprehensive and well-maintained sources of geographic data available, containing over 12 million unique location names across 250 countries [@dignazio2014cliff]. CLIFF API has detailed information on its locations, and we retrieve and convert the country codes of each location to assign the article to a specific location(s). We implement several corrections to the underlying CLIFF system.

[6]Given differences in temporal scale and substantive focus, we find limited utility in cross-validation with external datasets (e.g., AidData).

influence in the Sahel. In our sample period, three Sahel countries experienced coups d'etat that resulted in a reorientation of foreign policy away from the former colonial power, France, and towards Russia. This pivot was multi-faceted, including economic cooperation, pro-junta propaganda campaigns, and diplomatic engagement (Nadzharov and Entina 2023; Gain 2023). However, the most significant developments included the provision of military support, including the presence of Russian special forces in Niger and Burkina Faso and Wagner forces in Mali (Hairsine 2023; Reuters 2024).

Figure 2 plots reporting on Russian Hard Power activity in Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger. Red lines mark coup months. In all three cases, reporting is relatively muted prior to the coup periods and then rises sharply around the coups, with sustained higher volatility afterward—especially in Mali (2021) and Niger (2023). These patterns are consistent with well-known shifts in security partnerships. See Supplementary Materials *High-Profile Influence Operations* for a figure combining all influence reporting into one index.

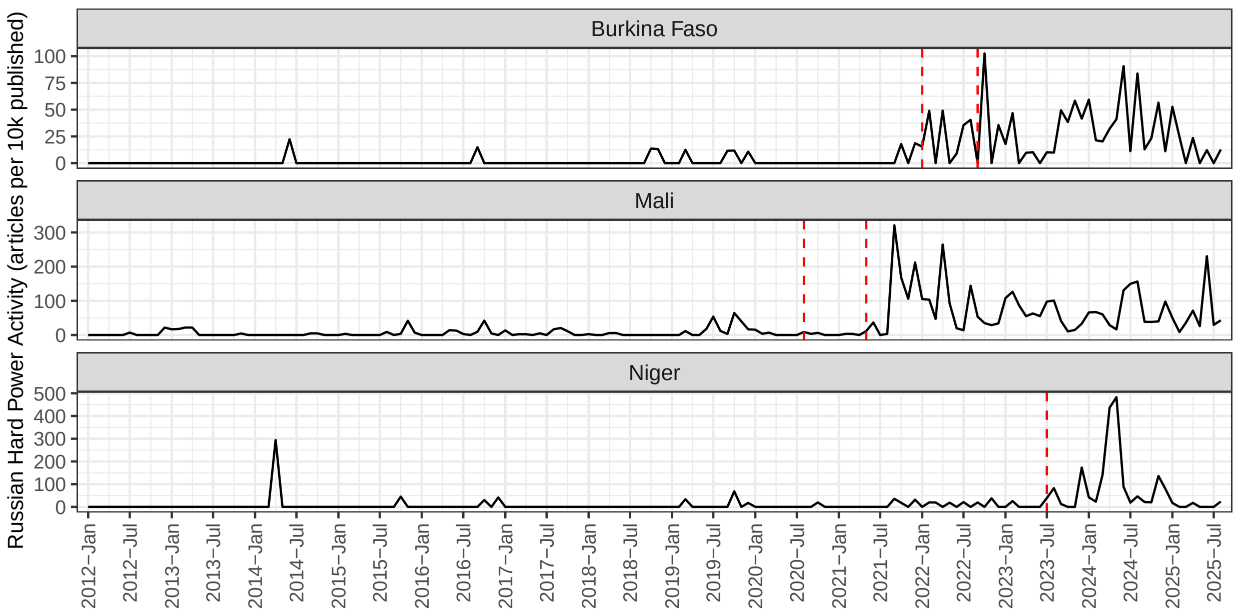

Figure 2: Normalized measure of reporting on Russian Hard Power activities in Sahel countries. Red lines indicate the month of military coups that marked a reorientation away from France and toward Russia.

For China, a similarly dramatic example has been the effort to secure formal diplomatic relations from countries that maintain recognition of Taiwan. Since 2016, multiple countries have switched diplomatic recognition to the People's Republic of China (PRC), following intensive diplomatic efforts that often included promises of sustained engagement and economic cooperation (Bock and Parilla 2024).

Our sample includes seven countries that switched recognition during the period (Burkina Faso, Dominican Republic, El Salvador, Honduras, Nicaragua, Panama, and Solomon Islands). Figure 3 plots Chinese Diplomacy reporting in these cases. In each country, we observe clear spikes in reporting around the recognition months, followed by heterogeneous trajectories—some sustained, others more episodic. Consistent with the multi-dimensional nature of influence, related shifts also appear in Economic Power and Soft Power indicators (see Supplementary Materials *High-Profile Influence Operations* for a combined index).

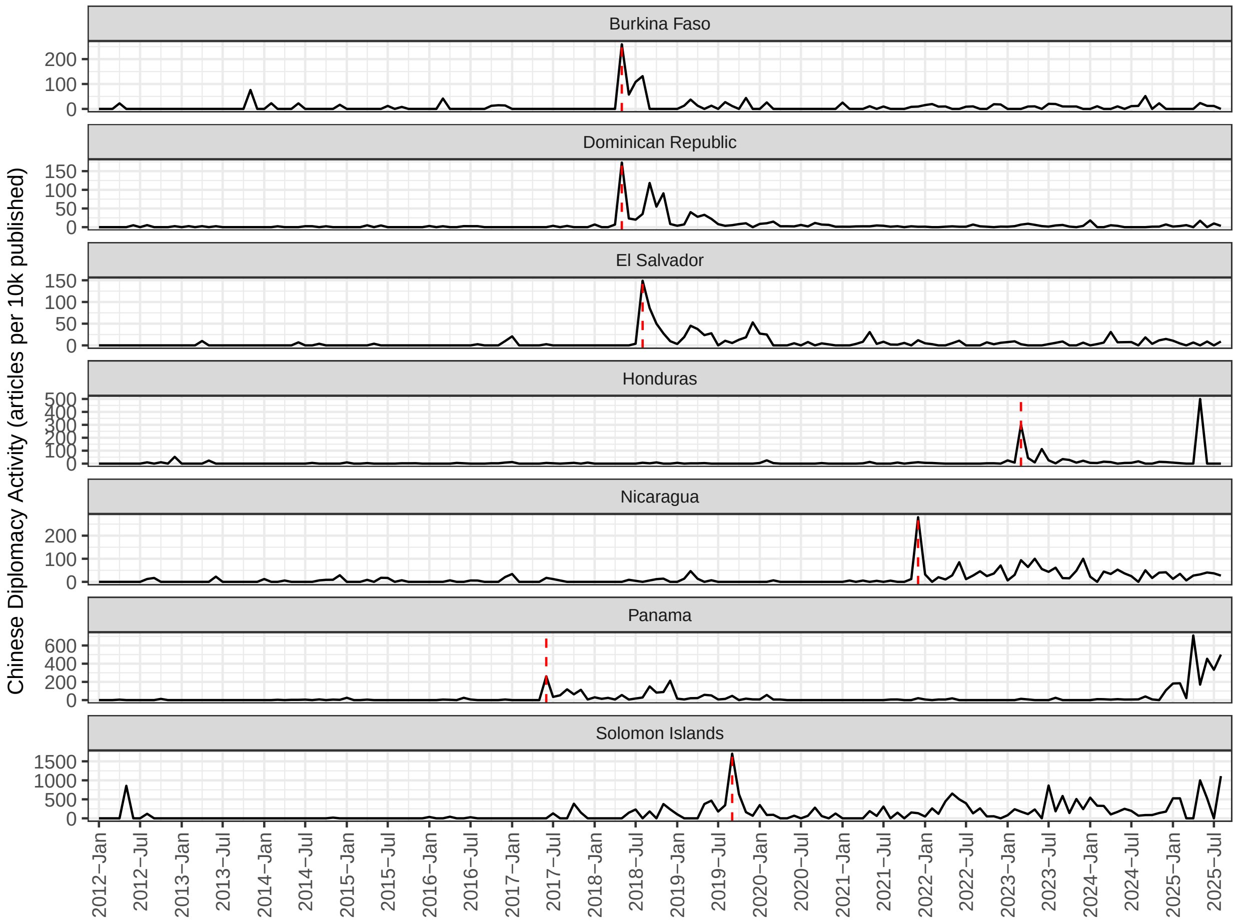

Figure 3: Normalized measure of reporting on Chinese Diplomacy activities in countries that switched recognition from Taiwan to the PRC. Red lines indicate the month of PRC recognition.

These cases illustrate recent, high-profile efforts by Russia and China to exert influence over low- and middle-income countries and show how RAI captures them. Our second validation effort involves assessing the capacity of our data to detect lesser know surges in RAI activity. To do so, we audit 86 randomly selected RAI surges across 20 event types and 40 countries. For each surge we reviewed every article classified as the corresponding event type, assess whether it is classified and geoparsed properly, and assess whether the RAI surge withstands any misclassified articles.[7] Across the 86 surges encompassing 862 articles, our surge detection accurately identified 88 percent (76 of 86) of them. The 10 false positives suggest two classes of limitations inherent in our work. First, in countries with low news volumes in the *HQMARC* corpus (for instance, Tanzania and Cameroon) our country-specific approach to surge detection is more likely to flag months with a small number of RAI articles; these low-volume surges are inherently more sensitive to even a small number

[7]For example, we detect a surge in Chinese foreign investment in Ghana in July of 2017. That surge was identified on the basis of 14 individual articles. In reading those articles, we find that all were properly geoparsed and that 10 were correctly classified as being about Chinese investments (in bauxite), while four were better classified as bearing on corruption related to Chinese investments in Ghana. The 10 successfully classified articles qualify as a surge according to our surge detection algorithm, so we assess this as a correctly identified surge.

of article misclassifications. Unfortunately, despite our best efforts to identify scrapable sources, we cannot increase the volume of media output in low volume countries. Second, in a few cases geoparsing mistakes result in falsely identifying surges. Geoparsing is inherently challenging since articles published in one country are often about events in another country. Individual articles in Armenia, for instance, might have bylines from the capital city of Yerevan but be about arms transfers to Azerbaijan rather than to Armenia.[8] Despite, these challenges, our validation efforts confirm that our RAI data correctly captures major, much discussed surges in Russian and Chinese foreign activity *and* most far less conspicuous surges. See Supplementary Materials *Surge Validation* for further details.

Describing Authoritarian Influence Using RAI Data

In this section, we describe *RAI* activity between 2012 and August 2025. Because *RAI* is a reporting-based measure, we treat the analyses as descriptive and avoid causal claims. In the remainder of this section, we zoom-out to analyze broader trends in foreign influence across aid-receiving countries. To simplify the analysis, we break our data into two historical periods: 2012-2021 and 2022-2025. We choose these periods because we see the nature of influence activity begin to change in the months around Russia's invasion of Ukraine. For higher-frequency visualizations, see Supplementary Materials *Dominant Themes at Higher Frequency*.

Throughout, aggregation from the monthly level to period averages is performed *after* normalization, treating each country-month equally. This ensures that shifts across periods reflect broad-based trends rather than a few high-activity months, and hedges against isolated misclassification errors. The approach does not affect the substantive findings.

We begin by using the six themes in Table 1 to describe the most frequently reported-on tools used by Russia and China. Specifically, we calculate the most frequently reported-on theme for each country-period. This approach counts all classified articles equally. Figure 4 shows the dominant *RAI* tool by country for two periods. The left panel captures reports of Chinese influence and the right panel captures reports of Russian influence. For China, Economic Power remains the most dominant theme across countries in both periods, while Diplomacy becomes dominant in a growing subset of cases in 2022–2025. When pooling across countries at the monthly level, Diplomacy's share of reported Chinese influence rises from 24% (2012–2016) to 28% (2017–2021) to 32% (2022–2025), suggesting a gradual rebalancing rather than a wholesale shift away from economic tools.

For Russia, the distribution is more mixed. Diplomacy is frequently dominant, but Hard Power becomes more salient in several countries after 2022. Pooling across countries, the Diplomacy share increases from 27% (2012–2016) to 31% (2017–2021) to 26% (2022–2025), while Hard Power shows a marked rise around the invasion period. These descriptive patterns are consistent with a shift toward more coercive tools in the 2022–2025 period, though they remain measures of reporting rather than direct counts of actions.

Next, we look at the share of all *RAI* reporting (both Russia and China) that is attributed to Russia. Again, this approach counts all classified articles equally; for example, an article reporting on a diplomatic statement by Russia would receive the same amount of weight as a report on a major transfer of technology by China. However, we expect that influence activity will receive coverage roughly proportional to its significance.

[8] This example accounts for one of our surge 'misses'.

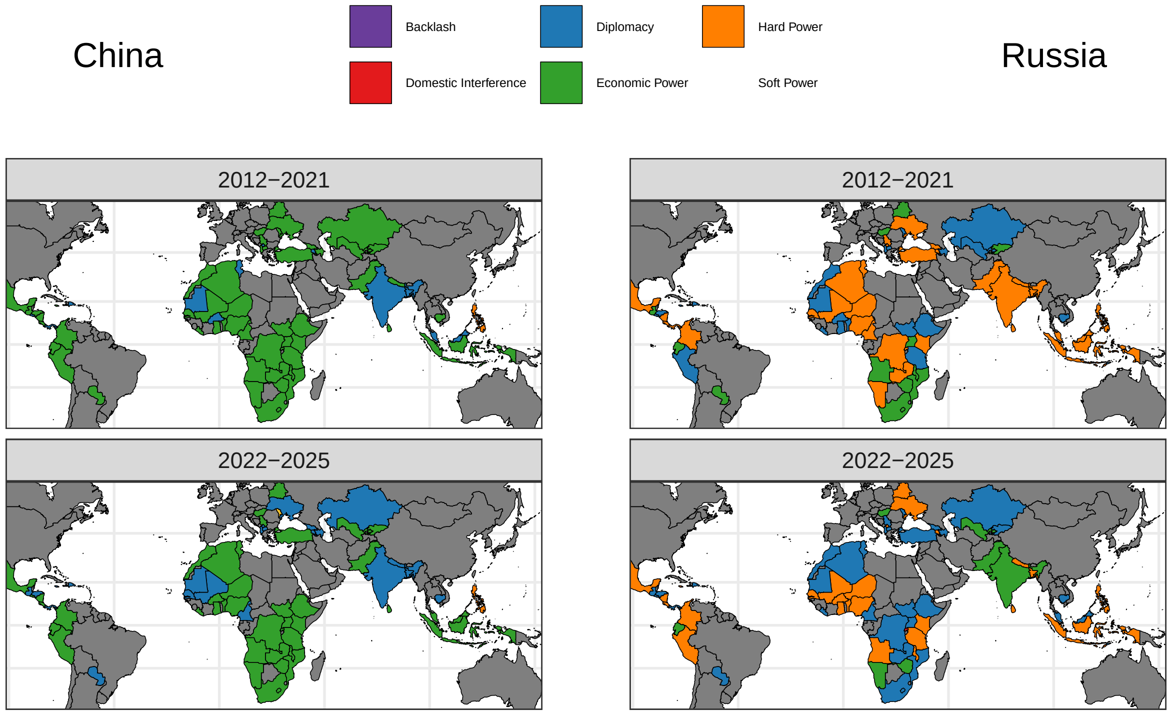

Figure 4: RAI tool with the greatest volume of reporting by country, measured as the normalized share of all articles classified into RAI categories that correspond with each tool. The left panel captures reports of Chinese influence and the right panel captures reports of Russian influence.

Figure 5 plots Russia's share of total *RAI* reporting (Russia / [Russia + China]) for each country across periods. Because this is a *relative* measure, it is best interpreted as the balance of reporting between the two actors. The map suggests that Russian activity dominates in parts of Eastern and Central Europe and several Sahel countries, while Chinese activity is more dominant in parts of Southeast Asia and across much of Sub-Saharan Africa. Latin America and North Africa appear more mixed. Second, we see evidence of shifts in *relative* influence shares over time. In 2022–2025, Russia's share of reporting increases in parts of the Sahel and North Africa, while China retains dominance in much of Sub-Saharan Africa and Southeast Asia.

These descriptive patterns correspond with popular narratives that highlight growing Chinese influence in Africa and Latin America during 2012–2021 and more recent accounts of increased Russian influence in Africa and Southeast Asia (Ferragamo 2023; Kurlantzick 2023; Gvosdev 2016). This correspondence provides face validity for *RAI*, while also underscoring the importance of cautious interpretation: salience in international discourse can still shape local reporting, even when coverage is dominated by domestic outlets.

In summary, the descriptive patterns suggest a rising emphasis on Diplomacy in reported influence activity for both Russia and China, alongside a post-2022 rise in Russian Hard Power. Economic Power remains central for China, though its relative prominence fluctuates.

The supplementary absolute-level plot (articles per 10k published) shows Russian and Chinese *RAI* reporting over time. Reporting on Russian influence spikes around the annexation of Crimea (March

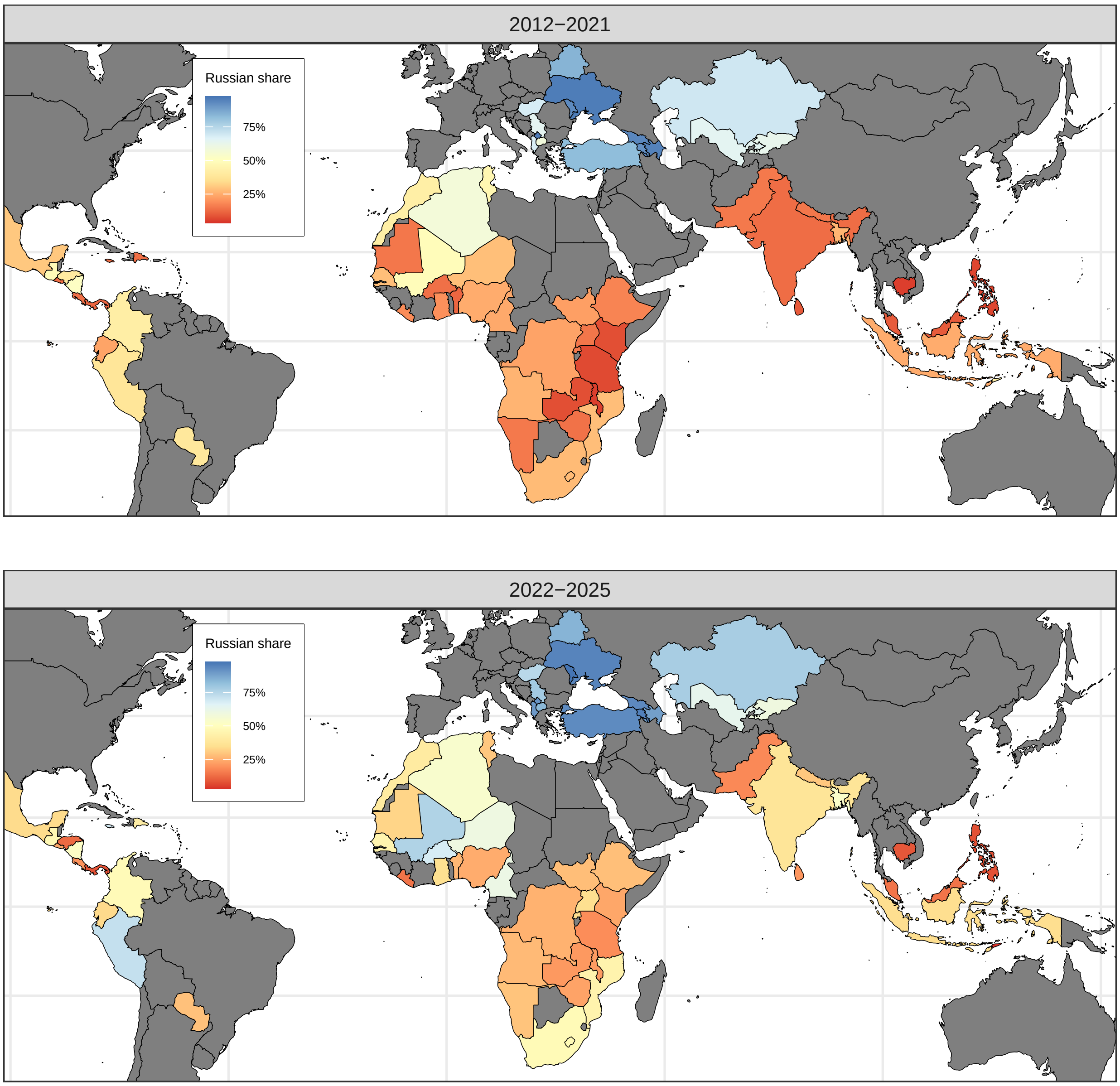

Figure 5: Relative share of RAI reporting attributed to Russia (Russia / [Russia + China]) by country and period.

2014) and again around the invasion of Ukraine (February 2022), remaining elevated through mid-2023. Chinese reporting is comparatively stable through much of the series but rises in 2024–2025. If anything, China appears to have withdrawn internationally during the pandemic rather than intensifying its influence efforts. Because aggregation is performed after normalization, the post-2022 increase in Russian reporting reflects broad-based activity across many countries and months, not a spike in a few cases.

The supplementary country-level period-change plot shows the percentage change in average monthly *RAI* articles between 2012–2021 and 2022–2025. Russian influence increased broadly, with especially large gains in the Sahel and in Nicaragua (Newshub 2022). Notably, the increase was weakly negatively correlated with prior Russian activity (-0.09), suggesting Russia expanded most in places where it had been least active. The pattern for China is more heterogeneous, with increases in countries where China deepened engagement (Ukraine, Honduras, Cambodia) alongside declines elsewhere. Changes in Russian and Chinese influence across countries were only weakly correlated (0.07), suggesting the two powers target different countries.

Use Case: Testing Expectations of Russian Influence Activity

Here we provide a use case of the RAI data by focusing on Russian foreign activity in the lead up to its invasion of Ukraine in February 2022. The use case exploits the distinctive, high-frequency nature and multiple dimensions of RAI activity to provide distinctive insights into Russia's attempt to craft support for the invasion. While we do not provide a test of an original theoretical argument, we do show that it increased activity in ways and in countries that are analytically coherent.

By fall 2021, U.S. intelligence suggests Putin had decided to invade Ukraine (Sanger 2024, 237–40). In response, the U.S. attempted to convince European allies that this violation of international law was imminent. We argue that Russia likely used this window of opportunity to engage in strategic behavior designed to mitigate international backlash. Knowing that many aid-receiving countries would be pressured by the U.S. and its allies to isolate Russia, we expect that Russia increased foreign influence operations to strengthen their diplomatic, military, and economic ties with those countries in the months before the invasion.

Why would Russia focus on diplomatic, military, and economic ties before a high-stakes offensive? Soft Power and Domestic Interference tools are designed to shape public attitudes or domestic politics over the medium term and are unlikely to yield immediate material cooperation. Diplomacy, by contrast, can quickly strengthen bilateral relationships, reaffirm existing commitments, and pre-emptively signal consequences for defection—making it well-suited to securing cooperation before an action likely to generate international blowback. Economic Power tools such as aid, investments, and trade agreements deepen interdependence, raising the costs of cooperating with US-inspired sanctions regimes. Hard Power tools—arms transfers, joint exercises, security agreements—provide immediate incentives for target countries and allow Russia to gain combat experience and test technology before a larger conflict (Goodson and Żakowska 2023; Kagan 2020). Importantly, these tools are most valuable when deployed *before* conflict begins; once military activities commence, resources shift to the conflict and the window for influence preparation closes.

To test these expectations, we use change-point detection to identify countries where Russia increased influence operations in the six months before the invasion of Ukraine—the window when the decision was likely already made (Sanger 2024). Change-point methods identify the time period with the

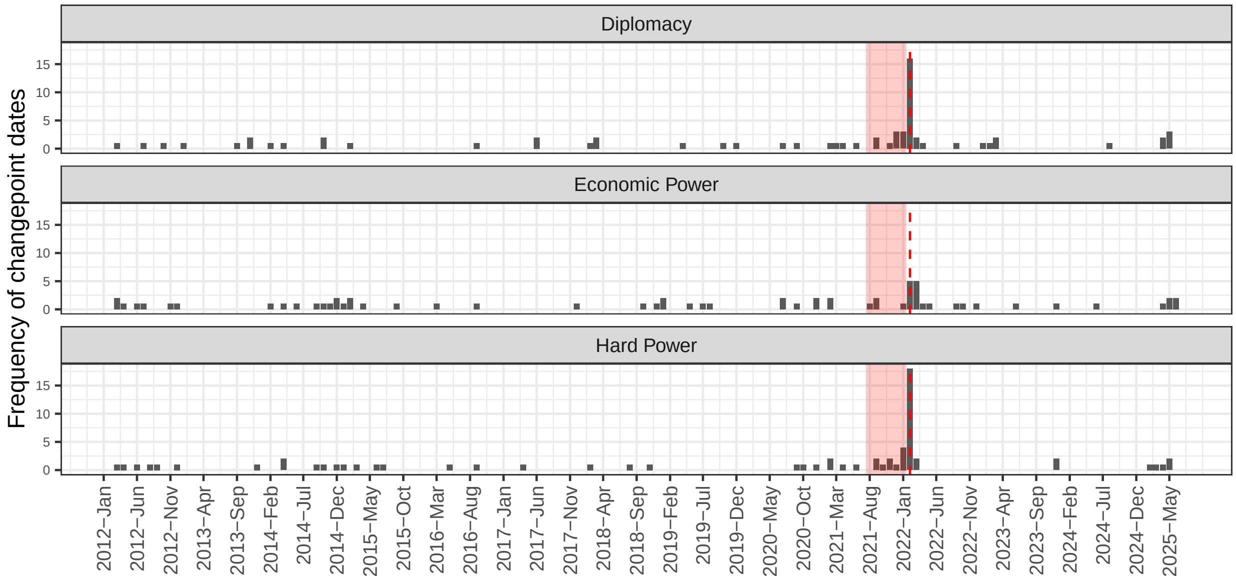

Figure 6: Number of countries with change-point per month. The red shaded region identifies the six months before the invasion of Ukraine. The red-dashed line is the month of Russia's invasion.

single largest level-shift in the mean of a time series (Fryzlewicz 2014). We apply this to each country-theme combination for Russia, recovering the month when each major level-shift began.

Figure 6 presents evidence broadly consistent with our expectations. For Diplomacy, Hard Power, and Economic Power, there is a clear clustering of change-points in the six months before the invasion. To test this, we count the number of countries with change-points for each six-month period and regress those counts on an indicator for the pre-invasion period. Across our six themes, this indicator is statistically significant for Diplomacy ($p < 0.001$) and Hard Power ($p < 0.001$), but not for Economic Power ($p = 0.581$), Soft Power ($p = 0.392$), or Domestic Interference ($p = 0.743$)—consistent with our expectation that the pre-invasion surge was concentrated in more overt tools. For change-point analysis of all *RAI* influence themes and to see each country with a change-point in the six months before the invasion, see the Supplementary Materials *Change-point Months for all Themes*.

For Diplomacy, 9 countries have change-points in the six months before the invasion, compared to 15 over the previous five years (August 2016–July 2021; an average of 1.5 change-points per six-month period). For Hard Power, 10 countries have change-points in the immediate pre-invasion period, compared to 12 over the previous five years (an average of 1.2 per six-month period). For Economic Power, we see 4 countries with change-points in the pre-invasion period, compared to 16 over the previous five years (an average of 1.6 per six-month period).

To investigate the nature of these influence activities and confirm that these change-point months identify substantive, real-world developments, we conduct AI-assisted qualitative analysis. For each country-month in the audit sample (change-point months from August 2021–January 2022), we pull all relevant articles from *HQMARC* (382 articles total) and prompt GPT-4 to summarize the key developments reported. We then assess whether each change-point reflects genuine Russian influence or misclassification. Change-point months are typically a period of slightly elevated activity *before* the main surge, not the peak itself. These initial months thus contain fewer articles and are more prone to misclassification, making the audit a demanding test of the data's ability to detect genuine influence episodes. A modest number of misclassifications aside, we find strong evidence that Russia increased foreign influence activities in the months before their invasion of Ukraine, especially in Diplomacy and Hard Power. Economic Power shows a smaller and statistically weaker pre-invasion surge. The reported influence activities underlying these trends appear consistent with attempts by Russia to shore-up bilateral relationships and encourage governing elites in target countries to maintain and deepen cooperation with Russia over the medium-term. See Supplementary Materials *Change-point Months in Time-Series* for full details.

Having established descriptively that Russia expanded its foreign influence activities in many countries before the invasion of Ukraine, we turn to a more analytical question: Where would Russia target influence operations to most effectively mitigate blowback? IR theory suggests three characteristics that might determine which countries were targeted for pre-emptive Russian influence operations. First, an influencing country might target countries that are ideologically similar. The leadership in ideologically similar countries may have higher baseline trust, easing communication and reducing the risks of sharing sensitive information. If the countries' leadership are pursuing similar ideological goals, the target country may demand a lower cost for their cooperation in an effort to further common ideological objectives.

Alternatively, influencing countries may perceive a lower risk of blowback from ideological partners relative to other countries. In this case, the influencer may pursue cooperation with more ideologically distant partners that would otherwise be highly likely to participate in international isolation of the aggressor. Similarly, influencing countries might seek to reinforce their ties with countries that have partnerships or ideological similarity to a mutual third partner. These "friends of friends' ' may be more likely to cooperate with competitors than direct friends, but still be easier to persuade than ideologically distant countries (Kinne 2018).

Finally, an influencing country might target countries that are strategically important due to economic reliance. For example, countries that export commodities on which the influencing country's economy is heavily reliant and unable to produce domestically may be more likely targets for pre-emptive influence operations. Likewise, an influencer may target influence to deter isolation by countries that they want to export to. For this reason, we may see an influencer targeting countries that are large importers of commodities that the influencer relies on exporting to maintain economic stability or foreign exchange.

We operationalize ideological similarity using UN Ideal Point Distances (Voeten, n.d.). For each target country, we calculate their average ideal point distance from 2017-2021 with Russia, China, and the Western Powers (U.S., U.K., and France). We treat the Western Powers as a single block because their ideal point distances with other countries are extremely highly correlated. Alternatively, ideal point distances from China and the West are strongly negatively correlated (-0.74), distances from Russia and the West are weakly correlated (-0.05), and distances from Russia and China are strongly positively correlated (0.64). Countries with lower values on their ideal point distance to Russia are considered ideologically friendly to Russia, those with lower values on their distance to China are considered friends of friends, while those with lower distances to the West are considered ideologically closer to Western powers.

We operationalize economic dependence by identifying commodities on which Russia is heavily reliant, either for imports or exports, and then identifying countries that trade in those commodities. We use comprehensive data on global imports and exports from UN COMTRADE from 2015–2023 (the latest COMTRADE coverage used in this update). First, we define criteria to categorize countries as import-reliant or export-reliant on specific commodities. Second, we identify countries that are major exporters of commodities on which Russia is import-reliant, referred to as *Import-Reliance Exporters (IREs)*. Third, we identify countries that are import-reliant on commodities for which Russia is export-reliant, which we term *Export-Reliance Importers (ERIs)*. We define two variables: *Exporters* takes a value of 1 for countries that are *IREs* and 0 for all other countries; *Importers* takes a value of 1 for countries that are *ERIs* and 0 for all other countries. See Supplementary Materials *Operationalizing Economic Dependence* for a detailed discussion and figures describing how these categories are defined.

Our dependent variable is an indicator capturing whether the country experienced the onset of an RAI influence spike in the six months before Russia's invasion. Using OLS, we regress these on each independent variable described above. For each of the three focal *RAI* themes (Diplomacy, Hard Power, and Economic Power), we run one model with all independent variables excluding UN Ideal Point Distance (UNIPD) to China and one model including only UNIPD to China. We run separate models to avoid collinearity between UNIPD partners. Table 2 presents the results.[9]

The clearest ideological pattern appears in Diplomacy. A one-unit increase in ideological distance from the Western powers ($range = 0.5$–3.8) is associated with about a 0.23 decrease in the probability of a Diplomacy change-point, while a one-unit increase in distance from China ($range = 0.08$–3.1) is associated with about a 0.32 increase. For Hard Power and Economic Power, ideological distance shows no consistent association; the only marginal pattern is a negative coefficient on distance to Russia in the Hard Power model.

Turning to economic factors, the Importer and Exporter indicators are not statistically distinguishable from zero across models. Taken together, the results point to modest evidence of ideological targeting in Diplomacy, but limited evidence that trade dependence systematically shaped Hard Power or Economic Power targeting in this specification.

Table 2: OLS regression predicting countries targeted for Russian influence in 6 months before invasion of Ukraine

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Intercept	0.56* (0.26)	0.04 (0.08)	0.18 (0.21)	0.14* (0.06)	0.08 (0.24)	0.09 (0.07)
Importer	0.09 (0.12)		−0.06 (0.09)		0.08 (0.11)	
Exporter	−0.07 (0.11)		0.05 (0.09)		−0.04 (0.10)	
UNIPD (West)	−0.23* (0.11)		0.03 (0.09)		−0.04 (0.10)	
UNIPD (China)		0.32* (0.14)		−0.11 (0.11)		0.11 (0.13)
UNIPD (Russia)	0.25 (0.17)		−0.25+ (0.14)		0.23 (0.16)	
Num.Obs.	51	52	51	52	51	52
R2 Adj.	0.034	0.080	0.002	0.000	−0.025	−0.006

Taken together, these findings suggest that Russian pre-invasion diplomacy focused on countries closer to Western powers and relatively distant from China, while evidence for systematic targeting based on trade dependence or for Hard Power and Economic Power tools is weaker in this specification.

Our findings have several implications. These patterns may suggest strategic behaviors that precede offensive actions likely to prompt international blowback, such as a Chinese invasion of Taiwan.

[9] Our sample includes 52 of the 66 countries in the *RAI* data. We lose 14 countries from the *RAI* sample due to missing COMTRADE data.

While U.S. intelligence agencies were able to intercept Russian communications that clearly indicated an imminent invasion, this may not be the case for future conflicts. In such situations, an ability to quickly detect early indicators of an invasion could be valuable. Future research should consider whether similar behavior is apparent in advance of other episodes where a major power expected competitors to push for their isolation. Future research should also investigate whether pre-emptive influence operations paid-off by dissuading targeted countries from engaging in public criticism of Russia, reducing compliance with sanctions, or reducing support for condemnations in international forums.

Discussion

The *Resurgent Authoritarian Influence (RAI)* dataset provides a multi-dimensional, high-frequency measure of reported foreign influence by Russia and China in aid-receiving countries. *RAI* complements existing resources by extending coverage beyond aid and investment to include diplomacy, hard power, domestic interference, and soft power—dimensions often theorized but rarely measured together. This breadth is a core contribution, even as it comes with narrower geographic scope relative to datasets like AidData.

Descriptively, the data show how Russia's reporting profile shifts toward Diplomacy and Hard Power after 2022, while China's remains anchored in Economic Power with a gradual rise in Diplomacy. We present both relative shares and absolute levels to avoid misleading compositional inferences. For the pre-invasion period, change-points cluster in Diplomacy and Hard Power; Economic Power shows weaker evidence; and Soft Power and Domestic Interference show no pre-invasion surge—consistent with our theoretical expectations. We find suggestive evidence that Russia's pre-invasion diplomatic outreach was more likely in countries aligned with Western powers, while Hard Power and Economic Power targeting shows weaker links to economic dependence. These findings illustrate how a multi-dimensional measure can reveal not just how much influence is reported, but which tools appear to be emphasized and where.

The data have important limitations. First, *RAI* is media-based and reflects salience in local reporting rather than verified action counts. Second, media capacity and press freedom vary across countries; we normalize by total news volume and seek to balance sources, but cross-country comparisons warrant caution. Third, covert activities—especially in Domestic Interference—are systematically underreported and should be interpreted as lower bounds. Fourth, coverage is restricted to aid-receiving countries, which is a deliberate design choice that precludes global coverage. Lastly, automated classification introduces some error, particularly for complex or multi-topic articles. Our workflow is designed for rapid retraining and audits when shifts in coverage suggest drift.

In sum, *RAI* advances our ability to track authoritarian influence at high frequency and across multiple tools. As great power competition intensifies, such data will be vital for scholars testing theories of tool substitution and strategic sequencing, and for policymakers seeking transparent, updateable assessments of how influence is reported in target-country media. Our infrastructure is designed for quarterly updates and expansion to additional actors and categories as the geopolitical landscape evolves.

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